been responsible for the fall of people's faith in the scholars, past and present, amounting to a disinclination towards the Religion itself '.

It was not surprising, therefore, that Akbar found the tenor of the discussions in the ibadat khana initially very disappointing. 'A horrid noise and confusion ensued,' admitted Badauni, as the ulema started arguing with one another. Akbar angrily told Badauni to inform him of any ulema 'who talks nonsense and cannot behave themselves, and I shall make him leave the hall'. Badauni whispered to Asaf Khan, sitting next to him, that if he were to obey the Padshah, most of the ulema would have to leave. Akbar, who insisted on hearing what Badauni had said, was much amused by this remark and merrily repeated it to those around him. But the crass aggression and vicious, low manner of the ulema continued to disappoint Akbar. On one occasion, Haji Ibrahim of Sirhind declared that the wearing of red and yellow clothes, usually reserved for women, should be allowed for everyone, upon which Sayyid Muhammad, the chief qazi (judge), grew incensed with rage, abused Haji Ibrahim in Akbar's presence, and 'called him an accursed wretch, abused him, and lifted up his stick to strike him'.

One of the very first issues discussed in the ibadat khana was the number of freeborn women a man was allowed to marry by way of nikah. When Akbar was told that the Prophet had limited such marriages to four, he is said to have remarked that 'in our youth we had not felt bound by this rule, and whatever number of freeborn women and concubines we wanted we have collected. What should be done now?' Furthermore, 'in justice to his wives… he wanted to know what remedy the law provided for his case', because he had not kept to the legal number permitted. That this was a matter that troubled Akbar is not surprising. In the convulsion of empire formation, Akbar had married a large number of women: Timurid princess, Rajput rajkumaris, Afghan noblewomen and more. From Monserrate's estimate of 300 women to Abu'l Fazl's fulsome description of 5,000 women in the harem, these large numbers were meant to reflect Akbar's munificence and splendour. Even a cursory examination of the quarters at Fatehpur Sikri make these excessive numbers entirely unrealistic and, moreover, of all the women in the harem, most were not sexually available to the Padshah. They included his aunts, his stepmothers, his Timurid relatives, and the retinues that accompanied the wives—their entourage of childhood friends, singers, cooks, masseuses, tailors etc. Even so, Akbar had far exceeded the stipulated number of wives permitted by the sharia